

D187

Differentiated Instruction

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

In a unit on ecosystems, a teacher with 27 students in a room next to the gym lets each student show learning by writing a report, building a model, or recording a podcast, all scored on one rubric. Which element is differentiated?

- A. Learning environment, because the room is noisy.
- B. Content.
- C. Product.
- D. Process.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher wants to differentiate process, not product. Which change does that?

- A. Students choose a poster or essay for the final project.
- B. Students choose to practice with a graphic organizer, a partner discussion, or manipulatives before the same final test.
- C. Desks are rearranged into quiet zones.
- D. Some students get a simpler text on the same topic.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A teacher who coaches soccer groups students for a fractions lesson based on yesterday's exit ticket showing which students can already add fractions with unlike denominators. The school uses a new math program. What is the basis for these groups?

- A. Readiness.
- B. Interest.
- C. General ability, which is fixed.
- D. Learning profile.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher lets students research a historical period through sports, music, or fashion of the time. Which student trait is being used?

- A.** Readiness.
- B.** Interest.
- C.** Learning style.
- D.** Product.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

Before a persuasive-writing unit, a teacher whose school recently earned an arts award plans groups using students' reading grades from last year. Which step would give better information for this unit?

- A.** The arts award results.
- B.** Previous teachers' opinions of each student.
- C.** A short pre-assessment of the unit's persuasive-writing skills.
- D.** Last year's reading grades, which are good enough.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

In a class that uses bright, color-coded folders, the “red,” “blue,” and “green” reading groups have stayed the same since September. It is now March, and unit data show several students have changed levels. What should the teacher do?

- A.** Regroup students based on current goals and evidence, and mix in interest and random groups over time.
- B.** Change the folder colors.
- C.** Move students only at the end of the year.
- D.** Keep the groups so students stay comfortable.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Over one month, a student works in a readiness group for fractions, an interest group for a research project, and a random pair for review. What does this pattern show?

- A.** Tiered assignment.
- B.** Ability grouping that should stay fixed all year.
- C.** Tracking.
- D.** Flexible grouping.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A science teacher with a new classroom greenhouse creates three versions of a task on photosynthesis. Tier 1 uses a guided diagram, Tier 2 a short reading with questions, and Tier 3 designs an experiment. What must stay the same across all tiers?

- A.** The number of questions.
- B.** Use of the greenhouse.
- C.** The level of support.
- D.** The essential learning goal about photosynthesis.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which is not a true tiered assignment?

- A.** All students analyze a theme, with tiers varying abstraction.
- B.** All students analyze a theme, some with a more complex text.
- C.** All students analyze a theme, some with sentence starters.
- D.** Advanced students analyze a theme while others practice spelling words.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

Several students in a quiet, well-lit math room finish the division practice early. The class is working toward a field trip reward. What task is most respectful for them?

- A.** Extra points toward the field trip.
- B.** Another page of the same division problems.
- C.** A challenge to explain when division gives a remainder that matters in a real problem.
- D.** Free time for the rest of class.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

Midway through a four-week unit on ratios, a teacher who writes the class newsletter sees from quick checks that five students have mastered the goal and four are still stuck on the basics. What is the best response?

- A.** Regroup now: reteach the four and extend the five.
- B.** Wait for the unit test to confirm.
- C.** Report the results in the newsletter.
- D.** Keep everyone on the same plan to stay on schedule.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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12.

Before family conferences, which the school holds in its new media center, a teacher plans how to share progress. Which approach best empowers students?

- A.** Show a slide show of the media center.
- B.** Students show evidence for each standard from their tracking sheets and state their next goal.
- C.** Share only the overall grade.
- D.** Share each student's rank in the class.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

In a unit on ecosystems, a teacher ~~with 27 students in a room next to the gym~~ lets each student show learning by writing a report, building a model, or recording a podcast, all scored on one rubric. Which element is differentiated?

Target word: element differentiated **Decides:** Choice of how to show learning.

A	Camouflage	The room was not changed.
B	Adjacent category	The ecosystem content stays the same.
C	Correct	The final demonstration of learning varies.
D	Confusion set	Process is how students make sense of ideas during learning.

2. Answer B Concept 1 • transfer

A teacher wants to differentiate process, not product. Which change does that?

Target word: pick the example of process **Decides:** Process = how students make sense of the ideas.

A	Inverted operation	That is product.
B	Correct	Sense-making activities vary; the product stays the same.
C	Confusion set	That is environment.
D	Adjacent category	That is content access.

3. Answer A Concept 2

A teacher ~~who coaches soccer~~ groups students for a fractions lesson based on yesterday's exit ticket showing which students can already add fractions with unlike denominators. ~~The school uses a new math program.~~ What is the basis for these groups?

Target word: grouping basis **Decides:** Current skill on the specific goal.

A	Correct	Current skill on the lesson goal.
B	Confusion set	Interest is what engages students.
C	Absolute language	Readiness is goal-specific and changes.
D	Confusion set	How students work best, not their current skill.

4. Answer B Concept 2 • transfer

A teacher lets students research a historical period through sports, music, or fashion of the time. Which student trait is being used?

Target word: name the trait from the adjustment **Decides:** Choice by what engages students.

A	Inverted operation	Nothing is adjusted for skill level.
B	Correct	Topics tied to what students care about.
C	Adjacent category	Not a style label; the choice is about interest.
D	Confusion set	Product is an element of instruction, not a student trait.

5. Answer C Concept 3

Before a persuasive-writing unit, a teacher ~~whose school recently earned an arts award~~ plans groups using students' reading grades from last year. Which step would give better information for this unit?

Target word: source of readiness data **Decides:** Last year's reading grade is not specific to this goal.

A	Camouflage	Unrelated to writing readiness.
B	Adjacent category	Reputation is not current evidence.
C	Correct	Shows current readiness on the actual goal.
D	Dropped element	Not specific to persuasive writing.

6. Answer A Concept 4

In a class ~~that uses bright, color-coded folders~~, the “red,” “blue,” and “green” reading groups have stayed the same since September. It is now March, and unit data show several students have changed levels. What should the teacher do?

Target word: grouping practice **Decides:** Groups have not changed despite new data.

A	Correct	Flexible grouping follows evidence.
B	Camouflage	A cosmetic change, not regrouping.
C	Adjacent category	Still fixed groups for months.
D	Dropped element	Ignores the new data.

7. Answer D Concept 4 • transfer

Over one month, a student works in a readiness group for fractions, an interest group for a research project, and a random pair for review. What does this pattern show?

Target word: identify flexible grouping from a pattern **Decides:** Groups change by purpose and evidence.

A	Confusion set	Tiering varies task complexity, not group membership.
B	Absolute language	The groups are changing by design.
C	Inverted operation	Tracking keeps students in fixed levels.
D	Correct	Groups shift by goal and basis.

8. Answer D Concept 5

A science teacher ~~with a new classroom greenhouse~~ creates three versions of a task on photosynthesis. Tier 1 uses a guided diagram, Tier 2 a short reading with questions, and Tier 3 designs an experiment. What must stay the same across all tiers?

Target word: what tiers hold constant **Decides:** One essential goal for all.

A	Wrong stem number	Quantity is not the key constant.
B	Camouflage	Materials can vary; the goal cannot.
C	Inverted operation	Support is what tiers vary.
D	Correct	Tiers vary complexity, not the goal.

9. Answer D Concept 5 · transfer

Which is not a true tiered assignment?

Target word: spot the violation **Decides:** A different goal for one group.

A	Inverted operation	Valid tiering.
B	Adjacent category	Same goal, higher complexity: valid.
C	Confusion set	Same goal, more support: valid tiering.
D	Correct	The groups have different goals, so it is not tiering.

10. Answer C Concept 6

Several students ~~in a quiet, well-lit math room~~ finish the division practice early. ~~The class is working toward a field trip reward.~~ What task is most respectful for them?

Target word: task for early finishers **Decides:** Deeper, not more.

A	Camouflage	Reward detail, not a learning task.
B	Adjacent category	More of the same, not deeper.
C	Correct	Deeper, engaging work on the same goal.
D	Dropped element	Drops the learning goal.

11. Answer A Concept 7

Midway through a four-week unit on ratios, a teacher ~~who writes the class newsletter~~ sees from quick checks that five students have mastered the goal and four are still stuck on the basics. What is the best response?

Target word: use of mid-unit evidence **Decides:** Evidence shows students have moved or stalled.

A	Correct	Adjusts instruction during the unit.
B	Dropped element	Misses the chance to adjust.
C	Camouflage	Does not change instruction.
D	Absolute language	Ignores clear evidence.

12. Answer B Concept 8

Before family conferences, ~~which the school holds in its new media center,~~ a teacher plans how to share progress. Which approach best empowers students?

Target word: communicating progress **Decides:** Progress against standards, with student ownership.

A	Camouflage	Unrelated to progress.
B	Correct	Standards-based and student-led.
C	Dropped element	Hides which standards are strong or weak.
D	Inverted operation	Compares students rather than showing progress on standards.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	5	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	7	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	6	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	3	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	What can be differentiated	Teachers can differentiate content (what is learned or how it is accessed), process (how students make sense of it), product (how they show learning), and the learning environment.	Mixing up process (the sense-making activity) with product (the final demonstration).	A described change and a question about which element was differentiated.
2	Readiness, interest, learning profile	Readiness is a student's current skill with the specific goal; interest is what engages the student; learning profile covers how the student works best (grouping, setting, culture).	Treating readiness as general ability or a fixed label.	The reason a teacher gave for grouping or adjusting work.
3	Pre-assessment drives readiness decisions	Check what students already know about the specific upcoming goal before planning, so groups and tasks match actual readiness.	Grouping by last year's grades or general reputation.	Planning a unit without knowing current skill on its goals.
4	Flexible grouping	Groups change often, based on the current goal and evidence, and mix readiness, interest, and random groupings over time.	Keeping the same high, middle, and low groups all year.	Groups that have not changed across units or goals.
5	Tiered assignments	Tiers keep the same essential learning goal for everyone and vary complexity, support, or abstraction.	Giving some students a different, easier goal or simply more problems.	Several versions of one task and a question about what must stay the same.
6	Respectful tasks	Every version of a task should be equally engaging and focused on essential understanding; advanced learners get deeper work, not more work.	Giving fast finishers extra worksheets of the same kind.	What students who finish early or who are advanced are asked to do.
7	Ongoing assessment and adjustment	Use frequent formative checks during a unit to regroup, reteach, or extend, rather than waiting for the unit test.	Setting groups once at the start and not revisiting them.	Mid-unit evidence that some students have moved or stalled.
8	Student-involved progress communication	Report progress against standards and have students track their own evidence and set next goals, so feedback empowers rather than labels.	Reporting only an overall grade or comparing students to classmates.	How progress is shared with students or families.

Course scope (public description): Differentiated Instruction examines how the classroom environment and students' readiness levels, interests, and learning profiles influence learning. K-12 educators taking this course will acquire a deep understanding of their students in order to differentiate their curriculum, instruction, and assessments in response to individual students' needs. This course will allow students to also learn how to effectively monitor and communicate students' progress toward standards and adjust their practice as needed to empower students and nurture their abilities and aptitudes. As a result of their learning in this course, K-12

teachers will be prepared to act as catalysts for differentiation within their schools and districts. There are no prerequisites for this course.